A NEW ORIGINAL SHOW BY **PAUL TOSH**

PAPER GUN



One man plays both sides of himself.

A SHOW ABOUT
SHADOW WORK

"We all carry shadows. The question is— what do we do with them?"

PREVIEW TOUR

FIRST PUBLIC PERFORMANCES OF A NEW OPERETTA

A SIGNED SCRIPT FOR EVERYONE

ORIGINAL MUSIC • STORYTELLING • INTIMATE • UNFLINCHING

PAUL TOSH

www.Tosh42.com

NOW BOOKING
PRESENTERS





An intimate, original musical-theatre work about resentment, identity and the struggle to let go.

TWO VOICES, ONE PERFORMER

E	The protagonist. Sung, set in upright type. He is the one trying to get somewhere.
N	The shadow. Spoken with an accent, set indented in italic. The voice that deflects, defends, and will not be held to account — until it is.
E + N	Merged. Indented italic, in bold. Both at once. These moments are the whole point of the evening.
Narrator	The friend. Spoken, set in grey. Not part of the argument — the one who was there for it, and stayed.
Paul	The author, speaking to the room. Set full width, between rules. Not part of the story.

Follow the type: upright is E, indented italic is N. The hat carries two colors, because one man is playing both sides of himself. And listen for the accent: the point at which it stops is the point of the piece.

You are welcome to read along, and equally welcome to close this and just listen.

A MOPERA PRODUCTION

A musical and an opera, to clean things up.

PATRON COPY

Signed for

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Born in Scotland. Son of Avril and Mori, both avid opera fans. Formed in piano bars in Europe. Seasoned across a decade of performances for senior communities on the American East Coast. Paul Tosh is a performer whose work refuses an easy distinction between entertainment, art and therapy.

His signature approach — The Song Is The Play — treats every performance as a piece of theater: looping piano, dramatic song, and the kind of presence that makes a familiar melody feel heard for the first time.

> *"Live performance is exciting; there's a great feeling between me and the people there. I am always improving one aspect or another. I was born, thank G-d, with determination, and with wanting to do better.*
>
> *Paper Gun is serious work, and I want it seen — but not just for its own sake. Because it gives something to people, and particularly because it can take someone out of misery, even for an evening. The goal is to bring people into sync — that's what music does. Here the psychology is doing it too.*
>
> *With an audience in the room, the full dignity of it shows."*



THE MIDNIGHT NOTE

14 OCTOBER 2026

So it's an extremely exciting time. It's like 2:30 in the morning. I finished the farm night shift. I'm looking at the stars. I'm realizing how close I am to something that's like a dream — to have such a project, such a collection of work, which you have to have tremendous energy to perform. But I know that it's the right thing. I know that it touches people very, very deeply. I want to say that, because people are coming for a long concert — which people do when it's, well, when it's good enough.

I spent all my time on my own up at the farm doing the night shift, preparing the concert — these original works. And I realized that had I not been put at this distance, I would never have been able to do it.

WHY THIS SHOW EXISTS

AN ORIGINAL SONG CYCLE / OPERETTA

Paper Gun, about a conflicted opera star, was built in senior communities — years of conversations and collected wisdom. Some of the people I met carry resentment, some carry none. The difference is the point of the show.

A paper theme tied to the shadow, and parallels about sacrifice. One man plays both sides of himself. The voice that seems to come from someone else is the one that turns out to be his.

Few people close the chapter and leave it behind. Unresolved hurt sustains resentment, and resentment goes on shaping decisions long after the original event.

Paper Gun is both an experience and an introduction to a method — a way of reclaiming a life from resentment. The ambition is simpler than that sounds. A song once said a thing for me that I had never managed to say for myself, and what I thought at the time was: it screams my scream for me. That is what I would want somebody to leave saying.

WHAT IT COSTS TO LOOK AWAY

It may take time to come to terms with something you couldn't face.

The cost isn't only the thing you avoided. Avoiding it changes how you see everything else, until you can't trust your own picture.

No single audience member participation is ever required. The audience is never singled out, addressed individually, or asked to disclose anything.

THE THIRD VOICE

Two voices do the arguing. A third one does not argue at all.

The Narrator is E's friend. He is not inside the fight — no position to defend, nothing to win, no account to settle. He is the one who was there for all of it and did not leave. That is why he can tell the story. A friend is a Narrator: he holds the version of your life you cannot hold yourself, and gives it back to you without flinching and without charge.

Notice where he stands. He never corrects E and he never answers N. He speaks when the argument has worn itself out, and what he says is always larger than what has just happened. Some will hear a friend. Some will hear something further than a friend — the one who has watched the whole of it and loves the man anyway. The piece does not insist. It leaves the door open.

And watch what the evening does with gratitude. It opens with a man who cannot say thank you — I've never been able to really say how I thank. It closes, at the end of Act Three, with the thanks finally said, out loud, to everybody. That is the journey. Resentment cannot be reasoned away. It can be outlasted, by someone who stays.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

What you will see tonight is one man’s version of the work — lived vicariously, from a seat. If something in it touched a part of your own life, there’s a way to begin that work for yourself.

At the back of this program you’ll find the protocol the show is built on: a way of turning resentment into grief, so that it stops costing you. It’s best walked with a trained therapist beside you.

PROGRAM

ACT ONE — THE TRAP — PAPER GUN

1. Pressures — The nerves pre performance
2. This Is Mine — Either generosity from performance or as a complaint
3. Beautiful Sunshine — From the high after performance
4. You Make Me Rock N Roll — Reason or excuse
5. The Visitor — The shadow arrives
6. Tavern scene — The expert arrives

6.2 The Work / The Journey — Moving is the proof

7. You and Your Own — Understanding the pattern
8. From a Watcher's Point of View — N observed
9. Who Knows Just Why — The protagonist questions himself
10. Paper Gun — The weapon named
11. Fear Hate — The universal warning
12. Don't Say Anything — The silence and isolation

ACT TWO — THE STRUGGLE — PAPER CROWN

1. Bully the Bully — Defense
2. Phenomenal Heart — Fighting back
3. The open secret — The impossible ask
4. Lemon Ice-Cream — She refuses the word. He sweetens it.
5. Two Faced — The unsent letter

5.1 "Torna a Surriento"

6. The Space Between — The prayer in the eye of the storm
7. Trauma Response — The most raw and honest piece in the collection
8. A Little Amnesty — The plea
9. Broken Man — The raw plea
10. Paper Crown — The turning point: vulnerability as the key
11. The Painting — soliloquy

11.2 The Destination — Arriving is the trap

12. Un Artiste — We sang alone

ACT THREE — THE EMERGENCE — PAPER HEART

1. From a Living Grave — The descent and the return
2. Painful Bother — Farewell to the dynamic
3. By Hertz — Reflection
4. Faith — The resolution
5. Rock N Roll / Sunshine — The return he rehearses, and never has
6. Just a Moment Away — Let me grieve for what once was
7. A Love Left Bleeding — The ceasefire, both of them sorry
8. Let Me Cry — The release / the prayer
9. Your Paper Heart — The only one who stayed
10. Paper Gun — The weapon, retired
11. Coming Home — for Christmas
12. This Is Mine — Reclamation / generosity
13. Opera Star — The world is made for giving

ENCORE

14. Paper Heart — I believe in your pain, I believe in you
15. For the Narrator — a friend

TALKBACK

WHERE IT HAPPENS

ACT ONE
dressing room · encore, opera end · on the way back to the apartment · her at his apartment window · the tavern

ACT TWO
the tavern with her

ACT THREE
the tavern alone / in the painting

One piano. Three acts. Forty minutes each.

Approximately two and a half hours, including two 15-minute intervals.

Paper Gun is a full-length work in three acts
not a set, an evening, original music throughout. It runs long and it goes deep. Twenty years of playing to rooms taught me what this material does to people, which is why it's built with care.

———————————————————————————————

PAUL

I've never been able to really say how I thank.

Is a tear coming down from my eye?

A friend like that you could never imagine.

I must've done something good, but why?

---

the Narrator

And we saw into his eyes and realized that, just at the end of his actions, our dreams could come true. This is the artist!

ACT ONE — THE TRAP

PAPER GUN



AN OPERA STAR IS WARMING UP IN THE MIRROR

E OR N

…Musing

Moota Chen Doh or Figaro … (warm up)

⟨ Lucio Dalla ⟩

E

When I hear your voice, I change my mind

1. PRESSURES

[The nerves pre performance]

E

Don't let the tensions
and the pressures overwhelm you.
Your standards are bigger than this —
fight for the right to determine the venue,
a place where meaning exists.
Kicking and screaming is fine if they drag you
to a world that is just the abyss.
Just remember:
value is not defined by vocation,
by season, but sometimes a kiss.

Look for no more in yourself or others.
No greater complexity chimes.
No standard or bearer of words or tunes,
however refined are the rhymes.
Seek to be seeking — live to live.
Reactions and actions combined.
Remember: triumph is a game, love is the name.
May the best man win

N

or complain.



PAUL

Every difficult relationship has two people in it. Tonight, they're both me. Say something true to someone you love and if the painter steps out of the painting, you are left in something beautiful, but holding both sides of whether you did the right thing… sometimes for a very long time…… Long enough, and you're a visitor, like your brother Jacques the Opera Star

THE FINALE OF THE OPERA

E

Now I'm on the stage
a Hollywood actor
would never do this.
…Tell us some more
The reason we are here is never a factor.
Just moving your lips.
You learn the score
We all know we all know
beluga caviar we all know
we all know Mesoud can play guitar
Officially I'm at the bar.
Provisionally with a Cuban cigar
I am I am. I am an opera star.
E – breathing in the applause +

JUST BEFORE COMING OFF STAGE FROM THE OPERA PERFROMANCE

2. THIS IS MINE

[either generosity from performance or as a complaint]

E

This is mine, but you can have it.
This is mine, but you can have it.
This is mime, but you can have it —
'cause it's all I've got to give.
“That’s the way it is, that’s the way it is, you only have in life what you give away”

ON HIS WAY BACK TO HIS APARTMENT

E

A thousand of them tonight. Not one of them will phone.

N

You call that lonely? Let me introduce you to people.

Frère Jacques

….wake up Brother Jack!
—we all get to choose what we regret.

Bing bang bong…..

THE PHONE RINGS, IT’S HIS EX

3. BEAUTIFUL SUNSHINE

[From the high after performance]

E

At the end of the day of marked success
I take out my cufflinks as I get undressed

I remember you as I climb the stairs
Acutely aware I was glad you were there
And even though I was asleep and unaware, (the tip off that the whole thing was a dream)
I was happy to have someone who cares.
And I'd wake up in the morning, beautiful sunshine,
I'd wake up in the morning all I'd see is You
all I'd see is You...

E

Hello

repeating what he hears on the phone

Great performance tonight – thank you, I'm like a little brother to you now Brother Jacques, do I regret that we broke up, was my career so important to me"

= "N"

Great performance tonight, You're like a little brother to me now Brother Jacques, do you regret that we broke up, was your career so important to you?!

4. YOU MAKE ME ROCK N ROLL

[Reason or excuse / a phone conversation]

E

And I wake up in the morning, beautiful sunshine,
I wake up in the morning all I see is You
all I see is You...
You made me rock n roll,
you made me take the can,
you made me roll.

E

I found my way to the edge of what's real.
I couldn't turn back without grabbing the wheel,
but my hands are tied —
because I try to even out the deal.
My circumstance is, as you say, it's in the song, the song is the play
It's where I am and where I'm found.
To love and believe is in the sound.
A combination somewhat rare —
You know it's true. You know I care.
And all us souls who take the reins,
and pursue our goals...
It's just the same.
So I don't forget —
Like you said: We all get to choose that which we regret.
But you made me rock n roll,

you made me take the can,
you made me roll.

N

And if I did complain, if I did abuse,
the rights I have, the rights I lose.
And you along with them it seems...
So I'm stubborn and lucid, and wanton to burn
including my wage, your prisoner's page.
But I'm sick of what's savagery, I'm tired of what's old.
Let me out of this savage, away from the bold.

E

And I wake up in the morning, beautiful sunshine,
I wake up in the morning all I see is You
all I see is You...

N

So me truly and simply, and all for the best.
my life is amazing — I still have some left.
No fear of referral, nor tears of advice.
Let go of your senses instead of MY life.

E

You make me rock n roll,
you made me take the can,
you make me roll.
It took a little time to think it over to see it through,
and you know I love’d you the way I do, even though I find it hard to say to you.

E

“hello, hello” (she is gone… hangs up)



5. THE VISITOR

[The shadow arrives]

E

In the summer, my lover comes south to visit —
the visitor in the visitors' windows.
But her voice has got the color,
the sound of "I don't care,"
and more like that than "this is fair,"
or "what the heck — despair."
I mean her pain, though not to belittle,
is classic in that she's starting to sound brittle.
But it's on par with all of our scars,
and we all find ourselves in the middle.

HE SEES HER AT THE WINDOW AND DIALS HER UP ON THE PHONE

So lets take a drink. Lets go for a walk and think,
and rest your weary brow.
I'm guessing here that just one beer
might not be quite enough.
Come on in through the window – I see you!
In the summer, my lover comes south to visit —
the visitor in the visitors' windows.

So what the heck — I'll get some more on deck,
and we'll sing a song with cheer.
I'll buy the round, you make the sound,
and together we'll shed a tear.

E

“I’ve been invited to this private party – ley’s go”

THEY GO TO THE TAVERN, shei s watching him holding court and feeling ignored

6 TAVERN SCENE

[The star & expert arrives]

Grand entrance “hi everybody” “you were amazing tonight, et”c.



+

N

I watched my little brother Jack he was complaining at this private party to :Gal Gadot” about:

E

“How come this terrible music gets made, .
and why is that, and how come it got bought....”

N

I said – it’s because there’s…. two market places out there!?”
There’s a market for it because There’s people out there
without a heart, and there’s people out there with a heart.

E
“that’s not entirely true”, he said
“more true is there’s a lot of people
who keep their paper heart a secret.
And sometimes it becomes
.....a secret from themselves…
…the only way I know how to tell the truth is through the opera and “some” modern art
but the new chemistry is marketing
- Jacques said, and he didn’t like to be “sold entertainment”
“you’d better not drink this or you might get too near a climax of reality” (holding a cigar)

N
he said in an American accent, to the Israeli entertainer and friend of Stephen Spielberg, who happened to be sitting behind them, as he gave her a taste of his shot, just after he compared New York to Israel due to its finger snap style of living

E
I’m sorry to say, it’s an age old fight
But I don’t take no liberties because of my rights.

6.2 THE WORK

[They are in agreement – and on a dime fall out when it comes to buying drinks]

E
Nobody wants to lift a finger
nobody wants to do the work
everybody wants to point the finger
everybody feels better if they call you a jerk

N
And a genius without action
is not half of a fraction
of a man with a plan
who at times suffers (even expensive) distraction

E
ADHD joke

N
It’s not funny

E
….I’ll get the round

N
Who me?

E
Not you!

the Narrator

I think every person, at one point in their lives, they had this strong feeling —

that they have to do something

E

….about a situation

6.3. THE JOURNEY

[Moving is the proof]

E'S FRAMING

I, I'm on a journey,
I, I'm on a journey,
You, you should have loved me,
And know that the truth had arrived (or: and know that the truth will have arrived)
And know that you had arrived

N'S FRAMING

But when truth, it is argued, the silence feels safer, it feels safer than honesty

N

Do I love you, yes I love you, but if you're not comfortable enjoy your journey

7. YOU AND YOUR OWN —SOLILOQUY

[Understanding the pattern]

E

It's such a shame when we re-frain
our nearest, dearest —
about the ones we need the most.
Who could have given us all we are.
And yes, I know you're not alone,
it's not just you — I know it's everyone.
But we pass it off, in saying we always hurt the ones we love.
You and your own
— it just makes sense in the battle zone,
not sitting on the fence.
You and your own
— it just makes sense in the battle zone,
not sitting on the fence.

N

But if you go, you'll be tested right away.
You'll be tested right away if you go.

E

You and your own
— it just makes sense in the battle zone,
not sitting on the fence.

N

But if you go, you'll be tested right away.
You'll be tested right away if you go.
So I stay.
Say what you like, do what you do —
there's nowhere else I'd rather be.

E

I've got a good reason for taking the easy way out….. now.

8. FROM A WATCHER'S POINT OF VIEW

[N observed]

N

For me?

E

Not you! I'd agree with everything you do.

N

Who me?

E

Yes you! But you've got to admire me for being so shrewd.
He's got two critics' eyes to tip if I extemporize,
coz he's otherwise.
He'll calculate evaluate
But the boom bada bing if you know what I mean
he'll just spectate
he'll look around to qualify his:
graduated, elevated,
never made it, compensated,
syncopated, un-dilated,
stuck on auto-automated answer —
Coz he's watching you
From a watchers point of view
"Who me?!"

N

Not you! he'd agree with everything you do.

E

Who me?!

N

Yes you! But you've got to admire him for being so shrewd.
from a watcher's point of view.

E

You've got two critics' eyes to tip if I extemporize,

coz you’re otherwise.
You’ll calculate evaluate
But the boom bada bing if you know what I mean
You’ll just spectate
You’ll look around to qualify your:
graduated, elevated,
never made it, compensated,
syncopated, un-dilated,
stuck on auto-automated answer —
Coz I’m watching you

N

from a watcher's point of view!?
Tell me what YOU’VE learned about love

9. WHO KNOWS JUST WHY

[The protagonist questions himself]

E

Who knows just why we turned around and hide
when reminded of love —
why did I try to pretend it's not there
when I recognize real love?
Inspiration leads to love.
So I wait for you,
everything that you do.
I can afford to dream.
If I know you know what I mean —
exaggeration needs to hope.

N

Against my ever persistent sound of intransigence

E

Tell me not brother Jacques
Tell me not for whom the bell tolls —
Brother Jacques
Wake up you could Be somebody!
the bell tolls for thee
Brother Jacques
Brother Jacques
are you sleeping,
are you sleeping
Sonnez les matines
Sonnez les matines
toll the morning bells

toll the morning bells
Ding, dang, dong,
Ding, dang, dong

9.2 TO BE

N

To be, or not to be — really, is that's a question!?
...Sometimes it is more noble
to suffer the slings and arrows
of outrageous fortune,

E

but at others one should take up arms
against a sea of troubles —
and by opposing, end them.
...To no longer die — to no longer sleep!
...And to no longer sleep, is to say: live.
… live with the heartache
and the thousand natural shocks that flesh is heir to!
But I see no consummation devoutly to be wished!
...Live! Stay awake Jack
There we can dream

N

There is no rub:
for in that sleep of death what dreams may come —
when we have shuffled off this mortal coil,

E

is that what gives you pause...
That the dread of something after life,
the undiscovered country,
from whose bourn no traveler returns,
puzzles the will...
...should it also make us bear those ills we CAN SEE?
Rather than fly to others we know not of?
Let not the native hue of resolution
be sicklied over with the pale cast of thought.
Let not enterprises of great pith and moment
their currents turn awry and lose the name of action.
You need to culminate phenomenal heart
To culminate: to bring together to the highest degree
phenomenal phenomenal
and a heart like a lion

10. PAPER GUN

[The weapon named]

E

Like a social misfit I play the scene —
"there's good and bad in everyone,"
So I think I'll come out clean.
Anyway you won't give me the pleasure;
you won't give me a rise.
So I'm blissfully unaware
of why I should be despised.

N

"Never rub another man's rhubarb" it's always good advice.
"An eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth" — there's a price.
But perhaps avert your gaze, and a little less self praise
when temptation fires your ego.
you'll notice in time you're not paying the fine —
"I'm all right Jacques" doesn't cover the legal.

E

But I am your enemy, my friend,
and till the bitter end,
You're the reason for my mindful treason.
it's broken — so what's to mend?

N

In hot and bloody cool disdain,
you've justified most every lie.
Morality can feign.
The end was over when the war begun.
Is this battle for identity or a paper gun

N

Gun paper gun paper gun,
gun paper gun paper gun,

N

gun paper gun paper gone
soon he'll be seeing the light
Bang bang bang bang bang

11. FEAR HATE

[The universal warning]

PAUL

one of life's greatest challenges

one of life's hardest things

is not to allow fear to turn to hate

sounds kinda simple

but I wonder if you can relate

One of life's most difficult things to do

Whether you're Protestant, Catholic or a Jew

is not to allow fear to turn into hate

I wonder if you'd agree

you can nod profusely at me

But if you don't really understand

you can show me the back of your hand

Yes one of life's most difficult things to do

Whether you're Protestant, Catholic, Muslim or a Jew

is not to allow fear to turn into hate

N

But can you be so disparaging and duplicitous and expect normalcy.

12. DON'T SAY ANYTHING

[The silence and isolation]

E

You don't say... anything!

N

You don't need me.

E

At all

N

At all

N

He was so generous on stage,
but in private, he couldn't give anything away

E

And you were so generous at home (sarcastic)
in public no-one knew I was alone!

E

I don't see you anymore.

N

Don't say anything —
is like it always was before.
And I can see you time and time again

E

Like never before I am five minutes you'll forget me
The truth will set me free.

E

You were always so cynical with words,

E

Coz in private I couldn't get a word in overheard
We could have been so close

E

…you were verbose

N

You don't say!

E

You don't need.

E

Anything

N

Anything

ACT TWO — THE STRUGGLE

PAPER CROWN

E
moota
maquando

1. BULLY THE BULLY

[self defense]

PAUL

Move on to the next subject, of course because the reason

You’re trying to figure it out in the first place

is to try and understand a bigger picture

which you’ve forgotten because the first act I gave you

made sense

But only for 5mins

And now Im going to give you something else

…just call it de-fence

N

He does not feel,
he does not chase,
he does not learn from his own disgrace. x2
Bully the bully.
The bully knows the things he does.

E

I don't believe you —
you're too cruel for remorse.

N

I don't believe you —
you're too wild for tears.
The bully knows the things he does.

E

And when someone calls her out
in a way that leaves no doubt —
I don't believe you.
Your tears are just another way for you to say:
(N voice) “Rather than get out of my situation,
I'm gonna punish you today."
The bully feels no remorse.
I know because this time the bully is me,

And the bully feeling is free.

N

AND I CALL IT DEFENSE

she does not feel,
she does not chase,
she does not learn from her own disgrace. x2

N

Move on to the next subject, of course because the reason
You're trying to figure it out in the first place
is to try and understand a bigger picture
which you've forgotten because the first thing I gave you
made sense
But only for 5mins
Before I said something else
and I call it de-fence

NOW ON THEIR OWN AT A TABLE IN THE TAVERN

E

don't let fear turn into hate

N

I don't believe you —
you're too cruel for remorse

E

I don't believe you —
you're too wild for tears.

N

The bully knows the things he does.

N

Bla bla bla bla bla-bla bla-bla bla bla bla bla-bla bla-

E

it's do-do-do dont call it-Dee-fence

2. PHENOMENAL HEART

E

to culminate phenomenal heart

N

You move and struggle you double your trouble
I'm bursting your bubble
your stuck in a boat
or the water your soaked
how do you float in your life

E

let it out and bring it to the surface
to culminate phenomenal heart x2
let it out and bring it to the surface x2
to culminate a nominal heart
I know it's in there, let it out x2
let it out and bring it to the surface
there it’s there yeh yeh
dadaba b aba ba daa daa daaa (with trumpet)

3. THE OPEN SECRET

[The impossible ask - N is introspective for the first time]

N

When I'm raw from something I saw,

E

…..Or rather: apparently missing

N

when I've lost that feeling,
the ability to relate,
I'm losing standing...
...forgiving.
To keep me alive I kill it inside,
vainly numbing out any old wishing.

E

So take the day off — why not!
Say you have a cough? Pretend!

N

No no. None of that —
you don't know where it'll end.

E

OK, so just be sincere.
Say — in your own way —
you don't want to be here.

N

But here is fine.
It's just a matter of time.

the Narrator

…between you and me: "you know that's a line."

E

A bit faster than mountains,
but slower than clouds.

Contradiction's the terms —
it's all that's allowed.

N

And in that deafening silence,
the open secret returns:
what's too long…..
…will we ever learn?

E the tipping off
…. it's been a while.
I see you've still got your style.
All laughs,
and in your eyes, no smile...

4. LEMON ICE-CREAM

[She refuses the word. He sweetens it.]

N

"Tart to the taste,
in your face!
Give me some space."

E

"I'm just trying to retrace."

N

"It gets in your eye —
you and I,
how, when and why
it always makes us both cry.
And still are few the times,
no matter the rhymes,
in between the lines

E

You’re ignoring the signs!
"Caught up in all of this,
I say: without a kiss,
a taste of bliss —
you're like my little sis?"

N

I'm not a lemon.

E

Lemon Ice-cream tears
are bitter yet sweet
Your heart may be broken

But it's just until next time we meet
Your soul may be crushed
but it's just until the next rush
Your faith may be lost
But is it a cost you're prepared to pay!
Lemon Ice-cream tears will come down and then
just remember they’re sweet
and stay on your feet
and you’ll never know an ice cream kiss
Oh little sis
From an ice cream heart,
a confusion of the art
…from a broken paper heart

N

I'm not a lemon.

5. TWO FACED

E

Just think of
what could be.....if
you accept what is.....not
what someone else said it should be
or should taste like
or should look like
or should feel like

N

You’ve got what is yours
and what is yours
is just not mine
doesn’t mean to say that you won’t feel fine

E

doesn’t mean to say that I’m out of my mind
1 2 3 and I think it’s gonna be
1 2 3 and I think it’s gonna be
just in case you think I don’t care

N

just in case I think I do

E

I’ll try to write it all down
put it in a song or a letter
but I’m not going to sing it to you
to your face to face

to face
two faced
“two faced”

N

don’t call ME “two faced”
it seems like only yester-day
you were in love
how can it be so, what do you need to know to let go

E

how can it be true, what do you need from me to
get to you

N

to get to who?!

E

to get to you.

E+N (N)

to get through to me too!

"TORNA A SURRIENTO" (COME BACK TO SORRENTO)

Ernesto & Giambattista De Curtis

E

What’s it going to take to get you to come back to me

N

Maybe if you play for me “Return to Sorrento!?”

E

FVEE DAY OH MARAY QUANTAY BELLOW
SHPEE RA-TANTO ZENTEE BENTAH
GA MEH TOO A’ CHEE TEE-ERRYA METHEH
GA SHETAH FOF EYE EH SOONAAH
A GUARD OH GWA
KAY STOOCH A REDEE...OH
A’SIENT SIEST EE SHOOR ARANJAY
NO PROVOH MARGUSS SEE FEE...NO
DEEN TOE KWA REH SHAY RAY RAH
WEH TOO DEE SHIOPARA TUAG DEE OH
PA LOONG TAH RANASS TOO DAWRAY
DASS TA TAA RA DA LAMORAY
KEEAY DAYOFAR AY LOO EH TOORENAH
MA ROOM MAY LA STAAA
DON DORR E’STOTO RED YERRO
TOOR NA SOORRYE-EHRETAH

TA MAY KAMPAH

N

I don’t know if that’s going to paper over the gap—
N IMPERSONATING AN INDIAN ACCENT
…it is what it is
"hmm it is what it is!?, it is what it is, it is what it is
but! what it isn't, what it isn't is what it is
- coz if you don't know what it is, that's what it isn't
-and that is what it is
• so what it isn't is what it is.
Well what it was is what it was - and what it was
is what it is when it was
What it's going to be, is what it is when you get there, but we're not there so it isn't what it is.
What it might be is never what it is
And it isn't going to be what it is:
"it isn't what itis, it is what it is" you can't say about "might be"
- it isn’t? ...
and that doesn't qualify as:
"it isn't is what it is, when what it is, is what it isn’t it doesn't, no!"
That’s it!

E

You’re always so funny about it. — Try living with it.

6. THE SPACE BETWEEN

[The prayer in the eye of the storm]

E

The space between
where we've never been…
...is what it is;
when it's not,
but what it's not is what it always was,
what it could be
I agree "that’s something else."
I’m talking about the space between
what things look like
and what each of us have seen
to the enemy:
just leave a little doubt.
The space above is filled with love,
but the space between
is what gets you there.

Ah, the space below —
too well we know —
in the space between
is what we won't show.
And leave a little doubt

N

Sorry sorry sorry
Thank you thank you thank you
I agree with you I agree with you I agree with you
The all come from the same space
That's the space between
The sorry is the deepest one, works on the ability to say sorry,
And you are working on the ability to say thank you, or: I agree with you.
Saying "I tried, and I failed, so I cheated" —
need not be to say you are defeated.
It may be the end,
but let to each, an amend
for that which is now completed.

7. TRAUMA RESPONSE

[At the most raw and honest]

E

I'm not surprised!
Of course I know you're doing your best.
Reaching for me — "it's not a test."
You want to give some kind of hope, but please — it's a joke.
The fact of the matter is:
I could always forgive, I just can't forget
when the past is in ever present —
no chance to choose to regret.

N

Ever need to
"vilify to satisfy."
So no belief in nature too.
Same for G-d.
That's the waste.
When we both are gone,
please G-d we'll get along.

E

If I could only let it go permanently,
but that means to be indeterminately free.
so I'm just soothing the pain as best as I can

to find a way forward to be the man

N

Why not try a little amnesty

8. A LITTLE AMNESTY

[The plea]

N

Ooo, when it goes wrong,
and it seems for so long,
you need both parties to be strong,
no matter the song.
If only one sings along,
or bangs on a gong,
there's nothing upon which to prolong.
And eventually it all stops.
Call the cops.
Some whistle raindrops,
others do the flip flop.
.....make real compromise!
But whatever the scheme,
in the lines or in between —
ain't nobody seen
all of the majesty,
as much as the calamity.
Well, if what you want is some sanity,
try to broker a little amnesty.

TRUTHFUL LOVE

N

Aren't you in the mood to sacrifice truth for love?
They say the road to truth...is through nothing but peace

E

They say the road to peace...is through nothing but truth

N

But the road to love
That's knowing which to chose from the above

E

In the summer, my lover comes south
to visit the visitor in the visitors windows x

N

But if you can't bring it through the front door,
Coz you think if you bring it through the front then it can be said,

And if it can be said it can be broken.
You can not say to me generously
A broken man you'll forever be

9. BROKEN MAN

[The raw plea]

E

G-d help a broken man
If that is what I am
Help me to understand
don't give me reprimand
don't bet me or vet me
but don't forget me, get me
don't free me coz u wanna be me
but don't deceive me
see me
don't astound or confound
I'm ground to a pound
muta d'accento
e di pensier

N

When I hear your voice
I change my mind
G-d help a broken man
If that is what I am
Help me to understand
don't give me reprimand
Don't test me or arrest me
but don't second guess me
bless me
don't schmooze me
or use me or lose me
choose me, excuse me….excuse me!
don't tug or shove
come with love

muta d'accento
e di pensier

N

When I hear your voice
I change my mind

10. PAPER CROWN

[The turning point — vulnerability as the key]

E
I once had a girl.
She said to me:

N
"Your problem is you're not available.
The problem is you're not vulnerable,
You'll give anything to the ones who can't ask you for it."

E
I said: "I can't be vulnerable with everyone."
She said:

N
"But with me you need to be,
so as you can be what I'd like to say is authentic.
Because after that,
the only way that you can be intimate
is if I feel that you were authentic."

E
I said:
"What's that got to do with being vulnerable?"
She said:

N
"Well if you can't be vulnerable,
how can you be authentic?"

E
I said: "What!?"
She said:

N
"If you can't be vulnerable"
E— selectively —

N
"you can't be authentic"
E— ostensibly.
I said:
"But I need to be in control."
She said:

N
"That's your problem.
If you have to be in control you can't be accountable,
and if you can't be accountable you'll never be vulnerable."

E

I said: "What!?"

She said:

N

"Your problem is you need to be in control,
coz if you're not in control
you'll have to be accountable,
and if you can't be accountable
well then you'll refuse to be vulnerable."

E

"Ahhhh" I said. "You're driving me crazy."

She said:

N

"That's right."

E

"Well let me tell you something, my dear —
there's one reason I can't give up needing to be in control."

She said:

N

"Oh yeah, what's that?"

E

"I'm insecure because of my that paper crown you gave me"

N

"Ah!"

E

she said.

N

"Now we're getting somewhere."

E

"Yeah, yeah, yeah — but the deeper reason I'm insecure..."

N

"Oh"

E

she said.

N

"Why's that?"

E

"I never had any faith in the first place"

N

"Ah, so"

E

she said.

N

"What you're telling me is:
if you had faith you would feel secure,
you wouldn't need to be in control,
then you could be accountable,
then you could be vulnerable,
then you could be authentic,
then we could be intimate."

E

"That's perfect" I said. "Well done.
Couldn't have said it better myself.
She says:

N

"Oh but the opposite is true — you'd better be careful.
I'll explain it to you:
If you really have no faith, and you're insecure,
and you need to control, and so you can't take accountability,
what you'll do is you'll vilify —
you'll vilify so that you can't be accountable —
you'll vilify, it's not as simple as not being accountable,
you'll actually vilify.
And if you vilify you'll end up duplicitous,
and if you're duplicitous no-one will want to be near you,
and that will be isolation.
So it stands you in good stead
to develop a little faith."

E

Vive la difference
That’s the difference
…. I don’t need this paper crown
Crown paper crown paper crown.....
Crown paper crown paper crown.....

11. THE PAINTING (& BACKDROP)

[soliloquy]

the Narrator

He pointed down the Italian river Street scene, where there's no one else there except for her and this situation. And he said to her with veracity as he pointed down the river Street with a scroll in his hand, he rolled up a piece of paper. he said

E

“Vive la difference, I don’t need the paper crown….That’s the difference”

the Narrator

-and she was gone.

the Narrator

And he was alone. He was alone in this beautiful setting, to be alone, to be alone for the rest of time. Initially, it seemed like a most horrible thing, but...!

Leading up to that she'd come, visiting, in the visitors windows. This parting scene had started with her there. There was an emotional hug, she said can we take it down a notch? The shadow of someone else could be seen outside... was she going to chat with them to deflect and avoid him as usual. He said

E

“We can close the window, and we’ll chat.”

the Narrator

They entered some of the usual competitive arenas; where everything's polarity, everything's some criticism of the other in some form, it's unavoidable.

It eventually led to her saying



N

"so you'd rather hurt me"

the Narrator

he said... he had the presence of mind to be able to say it for the first time

E

"I'm not trying to hurt you, I'm trying to prevent myself from being hurt.... and THAT'S the difference".

the Narrator

Before that there was some interaction and dialogue - and he was trying to hug her as if to say;

E

that's what I have to say,

the Narrator

but it was also impossible. She was too stiff. It was impossible.

Before that he said,

E

"maybe I can play some piano.
I dream this amazing melody

OR

I'm doing some interesting stuff these days.

the Narrator

He played a little bit…."

E

In the summer, my lover comes south to visit the visitors in the visitors windows

the Narrator

…but that didn't last. she'd come to visit him, yes, but it was to wonder what was going on, as if to wonder

N

"what's wrong",

the Narrator

of course he would be the one to venture to say

E

"OK lets talk!!

the Narrator

And he managed to prattle on about quite a few things, but it wasn't landing.

Left alone in what looks like this Turner Venetian oil painting - beautiful sunshine -- with beautiful buildings lining into the distance - which are probably not really either but that's what had been painted around him, to then have the painter removed from the painting the second he hit her with that final line,

E

"that's it, "that's the difference"

11.2 THE DESTINATION

[Arriving is the trap]

E

Sometimes the destination is a trap. The journey is where it’s at. I wonder if you can atestify to that.
When faster than mountains, but slower than clouds.
Contradiction's the terms —it's all that's allowed.
And in that deafening silence, the open secret returns:
what's too long…...…will we ever learn?

12. UN ARTISTE

[we sang alone]

Jacques
And so we sang together we sang together we sang alone
In the middle of the noise on a crowded day,
I can hear myself and you know I want to say something
An artist has to make some room and everything he seems
taking that the higher lines are free
And so we sang together we sang together we sang alone.
And how it feels to be seen and known
for what you have and what you let go, and let show
and how it feels to be dreaming, though
everything's really quite sad, but I'm glad for what I have
If an artist has to make some room and everything he seems,
tell me really, are the higher lines ever free
and so we sang together we sang together we sang alone
Finally letting him go, finally sitting down finally what I know,
laughing like a clown in town

N

He doesn't care about the physical
it's too political for his visible,
lyrical, spiritual melody.

E

He cares about the sense of it.
He's into the defense of it,
but not with violence or silence he is free.

N

He doesn't care about the surreptitious
he's into helping you get rid of
the delicious and malicious monkey on your back

E

Taking that the higher lines

Taking that the higher lines

N

Taking that the higher lies

Come with a fee

ACT THREE — THE EMERGENCE

PAPER HEART

PAINTING BACKDROP without shadow figure

E

⟨ Lucio Dalla ⟩

1. FROM A LIVING GRAVE

[The descent and the return]

E

The day is over
The war is lost
There's naught to do
But count the cost
Far beyond
the twist of hope
Past the point
Of buying a rope
Death of faith and spirit too
Resignation all to do
Lines of poetry, will they save...
Except to sleep...from a living grave

N

I realize I could have helped you
Even though I could never help myself
It doesn't do to tell me now why
I'm left on the shelf
Left alone in silence
Far from any voice
Still not believing & self-deceiving
As if I have a choice
Far removed from my truly loved one
All in the name of expectation
yet caught in the fear of all things near
due to past relation
But you are imbued with beauty still



You leave the others in the dark
Cast by your shadow of endless light
Eclipsed only by the water mark of this Noah's Ark

2. PAINFUL BOTHER

[Farewell to the dynamic]

E
but when hate consumes you inhale the fumes,
and even more so come to anger,
love is a reality —
but not at the price of all sanity
So fare thee well on the rest of your journey
Life is short.
I'll see you in hell —
just as sorry for what I'm not.
Where your charm and humor

N
unless of course G-d is a rumor

E
and being made of ice

N
just as you are so nice

E
will catch no sympathy

N

"perhaps it's all serendipity".

E

to save you the heat,
perhaps you'll suggest people are just pieces of meat

3. BY HERTZ

[Reflection]

N

You make me feel like I sold out a friendship
I always feel you feel me a fraud
I guess I can see the contention
Simply laughing was hard to applaud
Coz it's true it is always as such
For tHis worLd is set up to be so
Things get to where they are going
And those who will know, who will know?
...those who will go

E

…a genius without action
is not half of a fraction
of a man with a plan
who at times suffers in distraction

N

In other words what I concede is
Perhaps I'm not so in need
For if the road I have chosen is just
One also travels in trust

E

But oh how you hurt me
without any questions
It pinched at the heart of a home
and I'm sorry I lost to invention
buy you, you re-calibrate on your own
just to get on the wavelength
Apropos to avoid just deserts
never turning to G-d for strength
As seen, and as measured
by hurts

N (WHISPER)

… *Wake up Jack*

Frère Jacques

E

In all this silence who can sleep!?

4. FAITH

[The resolution]

P V

E

ED IL MIO BACIO SCIOGLIERÀ
IL SILENZIO CHE TI FA MIA!
MA IL MIO MISTERO È CHIUSO IN ME
IL NOME MIO NESSUN SAPRÀ!
NO, NO, SULLA TUA BOCCA LO DIRÒ
QUANDO LA LUCE
TRANSLATION OPTIONAL
And my kiss will break the silence, that makes you mine!
But my secret is hidden within me
My name no one shall know
But on your mouth I will tell it
When the light shines
Soon they'll be seeing the light, bang bang bang bang bang

N

When things don't seem white or black,
it's a time to stop — but not look back.
It's time to rest and see what tomorrow will be.
If you want, call it a test.
But be assured that He knows best.
His truth abounds without a sound,
even in a mess.
If you see the good,
you'll see the best
You're not naive to trust.
In fact, it's the opposite for us —
when things seem bad, try faith, a tad.
I know, it's easier said than done,
be it money, health, or love, or losing someone.
His truth abounds without a sound,
even in a mess.
If you see the good you'll see….
HaKadosh Baruch Hu: "VINCERÒ" "VINCERÒ"…
…And I wake up in the morning — beautiful sunshine —
I wake up in the morning, all I see is You

5. ROCK N ROLL / SUNSHINE

[The fantasy return —rehearsed, and never had]

N

You make me rock n roll,
You make me take the can,
You make me roll.

E

And I wake up in the morning — beautiful sunshine —
I wake up in the morning, all I see is You.

N

So what do we do? We stick at it for what we knew.
But the situation's always on the brink.
How do we mend this painting?
I tell you what — this is how I'm starting:
telling you now that I'm in for keeps.

E

What did I do to deserve someone like you?

N

What did I say, you tell me the things I do make you go away?

E

I really didn't mean to hurt you that way. Tell me you don't mean all the things you say.

N

True sometimes we say the things we don't want to do.

E

You say that we can understand if we land a hand

N

if we stay for the fight if we hang in there tonight

E

And I wake up in the morning — beautiful sunshine —
I wake up in the morning, all I see is You.

N

You make me rock n roll,
You make me take the can,
You make me roll.

E

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
For thou art more beautiful than anything Shakespeare could say.

N

Shall I compare thee to a starry starry night?
Thou art more dazzling than anything Vincent tried to hold in sight.

E

None of that was ever said. — I just know it by heart
Best not to forget — We all get to choose what we regret.

N

So you're still not in the mood to sacrifice truth for love?

EVERYONE GATHERED AROUND N LAUGHING

6. JUST A MOMENT AWAY

[for what once was].

E

You know I love you
I can't let the truth get in the way
you know I loved you
"AM I IN THE MOOD TO SACRIFICE TRUTH FOR LOVE?!!!"
regardless, that's what I want to say
it always seems
like just a moment away
I hope you're ok
just a moment away
I hope you're ok
that's what I want to say
What has love become
if it's not being willing to die for someone
That you want to kill anyway
Usually for the things they don't say.

N

….you don't say anything

E

With everything so unspoken,
It should not be thus.
If I could just forgot what it's like to think,
to think to think of us as us.
Let me grieve
what once was —
that soothing,
makes reminded of.
Let me grieve
what once was —
that soothing,
makes reminded of.
But I miss you so much
So much of the time.

I know you miss someone.
I wish it was mine
When you speak everyone laughs
and there are many tall giraffes
who are leaning down
to listen for that sound
It’s just a moment away

E

N

they say grief is love that has nowhere to go,

E

tell me something I don't already know.
No one escapes it, and it seems to be so —

N

I'm inclined also to "that's how it goes…
And brother Jack
“….I KNOW YOUR GETTING ANXIOUS TO CLOSE

Some traditions are wiser,
and so it is thus:
made in an acceptable way,
and expected of us.
Let me grieve
what once was if it ever was
That crying makes
Not forgotten of…..
But not resentful of
Let me grieve
what once was if it ever was
That crying makes
Reminded of
Not forgotten of…..
… not resentful of

7. A LOVE LEFT BLEEDING

[the ceasefire, both of them sorry].

E

Such a lovely day
People are so nice
And here am I
The loser
Who just lost a little more than twice

The dreamer who kept an open door
In the face of endless denial
Unfazed by every trial
Up until now
When actual bliss
In a simple kiss
Is what's to be denied
For some reason, unspecified,
unsupplied, mystified

N

Perhaps detachment
on a self-preserving slide
Or instilled by such wanting
a paradox of pride

E

Critically framed as needing

E + N

And there you have it
Love
left bleeding

E

I love you

N

So why don't you call

E

It's too painful

N

So that's love!?

E

It's mixed with fear
I just want to hear something true

N

What can I do?

E

Sadly by now it's all a mess

N

I miss you

E

I think I understand, but I'm not sure you really do

N

I'm sorry

E

Me too

PAGLIACCI

E

Dbm (but the note is B)
RIDI, PAGLIACCIO,
B/Ab
SUL TUO AMORE INFRANTO!
Dbm B/Ab
RIDI DEL DUOL,
Eb Ab
CHE T'AVVELENA IL COR! (cry treuuahh)
⟨ Lucio Dalla ⟩

N

LAUGHING CLOWN, AT YOUR BROKEN LOVE!
LAUGH AT THE GRIEF THAT YOU'RE PRISONER OF
IT POISONS YOUR HEART

8. LET ME CRY

[The release / the prayer]

E

When I think of the pain
that we've been through
and I think about how it's true
That everything
that we'd been through
should have been another step closer too
How could I say
What did I know

N

... you know a lot

At least to cry is something,
that we knew how to do
at least to cry is something,
and how would I cry with you
with our tears we found a way
we recognized what we want to say
Even though the pain held us inside
we knew the tears were not pride

the Narrator

Let me cry for those who need it most

Let me cry for those due to meet the unknown
and a heartfelt plea to revive my soul
To light a bright torch
a lover that really was only a habit
a parent that was warm but cruel
or the friend who always though of you as a fool
And we'd waste away these hours



doing one thing right
I'm not trying to say
"I'm trying to say I know what's right"
What I'm trying to say
is please let me cry
what I'm trying to say
is please let me give,
with our tears we'd find a way
we'd recognize what we want to say
What I'm trying to say
is please let me cry
what I'm trying to say
is please...

the Narrator

"there's something needs to be done. It's like something in you that says I need to do this. And if I don't do anything else, I know that I know that I know that I have to do this.

I think every person, at one point in their lives, they had this strong feeling —

that they have to do something, about a situation. Maybe they were raised in a way that they shouldn't.... I'm saying something must be done.

It's like one of those people who need to climb Mt Everest: it requires years of training, and then facing the unknown up there.

So many have tried and they have failed, and some have even lost their lives —

lo aleinu. I don't have more words to cont..."

Wind sound

E

Saying "I tried, and I failed, so I cheated" —
need not be to say I'm defeated.
It may be the end,
but to each, an amend
for that which now is completed.

N (WHISPER)

"Wake up Brother Jacques!"
... Frère Jacques
Brother Jack
Are you asleep
Are you asleep
Sonnez les matines.

9. YOUR PAPER HEART

[The only one who stayed]

N

What else can I do
you look so blue
a shoulder to cry on
or you can rely on
but I can't decide
what to tell to those eyes
to those eyes
what if I wipe those tears
even holding back the pain
that I know you've been hiding
you can put it in writing
you don't have to tell me why

It's the hardest thing to try
There is nowhere else you'd rather be
there is no one else you'd rather see.
We know there's no one else as close to me
laughing at the sea.
Oh there is nowhere else you'd rather be
I know there is no one else you'd rather see
I know there's nowhere else in modern art
With a broken paper Heart
Look at these soaking eyes
what need no-one tries

10. PAPER GUN

[reprise]

E

Gun paper gun paper gun,
gun paper gun paper gone,
gun paper gun paper gun
soon they'll be seeing the light
…..did I wait too long to turn the lights back on

E

"Please open the door the window is broken, we've been here before pacing these holes trying to talk over the silence. Pride sticks out, his tongue laughs at the portrait that we become stuck in a frame unable to change I was wrong. I'm late, but I'm here right now trying to find forgiveness what you show me how, time can make you blind. I can see you now that we're laying in the darkness did I wait too long to turn the lights back on."

11. COMING HOME

N

The Christmas bells
are ringing now
I heard u say!
You better get it right now,
& how you feel about coming home
Just a little smile
just a little feeling of what you've been
missing for a while
in every song you play.
I'm coming home for Christmas

E

⟨ Lucio Dalla ⟩

N

The angels cry for what you know
just close your eyes and just let go
Now close the door,
turn on the light
I'll tell you more,
when you arrive tonight
and come on home for Christmas

N

Even with a paper heart, and your paper crown, and your paper gun.
“that’s the way it is, you only have in life what you give away”

12. THIS IS MINE

[Reclamation / generosity]

This is mine, but you can have it.
This is mine, but you can have it.
This is mime, but you can have it —
'cause it's all I've got to give.

13. OPERA STAR

E

viarno viarnon cop I am bayaa
funiculi funicula x 2
yam I am ayaa funiculi funicula viarno
I say la ra nee ne may-ess al yet ay
tu sah ya doh
I lost to corin drat of few dispyet ay
fa may no mo
A do... no fort o goshe masi koolyay
e rasa sta
e lo...n ta corpio yes eron tes true-yay
su lan baga
viarno viarnon cop I am bayaa
funiculi funicula x 2
yam I am ayaa funiculi funicula viarno=i&vox

N + E

Some say, the world is made for joy giving.
Well, so do I
You mustn't change.
Some say I'm far too busy making a living.
So take a break.

…They take. Break!!!
But me, I'm on the stage
a Hollywood actor
would never do this.
Tell us some more
The reason we are here is never a factor.
Just moving your lips.
You learn the score
We all know we all know
beluga caviar we all know
we all know the truth is never far. (Mesoud can play guitar)
Officially I'm at the bar.
Provisionally with a Cuban cigar (holding a cigar)
I am I am. I am an opera star.

C U R T A I N

E N C O R E

14. PAPER HEART



[so far away]

ref: culm, rokn, sun, artist, yyo, gun - cry
ref: cry
E
I believe in your pain, I believe in you
it seems the same with no refrain
And so a claim to sharing love
N
ref: culm
what did I do
to deserve someone like you
Call it a gift
You make me rock ‘n’ roll You make me take the can
And I wake up in the morning, beautiful sunshine
ref: rokn
ref: sun
in truth we drink
and then we share
Where others fear
ought not to dare
An artist has to make some room
N
ref: artist
on common ground
sadly sound
from dealing with
the weights we lift
N
ref: yyo
I mean ourselves
Well what the hell
even if I’m mistaken
As far as I’m concerned
You’re taken
N
ref: gun

WHISPER: “bang bang bang Wake up Brother Jacques!”



And I wake up in the morning, all I see is You
.... Shave and a haircut two bits.

PAUL

Move on to the next subject, of course because the reason

You’re trying to figure it out in the first place

is to try and understand a bigger picture

which you’ve forgotten because the first three acts I gave you

made sense

But only for 5mins before I gave you something else

…don’t called it de-fence

The thank yous

Do you want to hear one more?...

This is the one I’ve never managed to say properly

15. FOR THE NARRATOR

[A friend]

E

I've never been able to really say how I thank.
Is a tear coming down from my eye?

A friend like that you could never imagine.
I must've done something good, but why?
There are things in my life
at this time all alone.
And even more dreadful
than I can postpone.
And there is not one nuance.
One character of pain.
That my friend doesn't know of
And truly loves me the same
In this amidst sadness.
Is a marvelous joy
It's almost worth it to savor
to suffer, my boy
Dear Lord, give me wisdom.
Dear Lord, give me strength,
Dear Lord, no more division
You've taken more than a 10th
But to him the world
Let him breathe in Your light
For whatever he lacks
On my darkest of nights
Made bearable and sweet
no other could I meet
in deference complete
I bow at his feet

the Narrator

And we saw into his eyes and realized that, just at the end of his actions, our dreams could come true, and when he left we were sad, but we understood that he did it to allow us, for there to be more space between, for us. This is the artist!

THE TALKBACK

TO RELEASE RESENTMENT IS TO GRIEVE

PAUL

Now we have the talk back section

PHASE 1

If you grieve the loss of something from a source of a resentment

The resentment goes

From the good thing that the source of the resentment has

Again, if you're really sad about the loss of the good thing that the source of the resentment also has

The resentment goes

To grieve it.

"To release resentment is to grieve. That means to cry about it."
And if you cant cry when you pray, pray when you cry

PHASE 2

Then grieving can give way to giving, because you stop resenting, and it's the resenting is in the way of giving.

Well it is what it is
"hmm it is what it is!?, it is what it is, it is what it is
but! what it isn't, what it isn't is what it is
- coz if you don't know what it is, that's what it isn't
-and that is what it is
• so what it isn't is what it is.
Well what it was is what it was - and what it was
is what it is when it was
What it's going to be is what it is when you get there, but we're not there so it isn't what it is.
What it might be is never what it is
And it isn't going to be what it is:
"it isn't what itis, it is what it is" you can't say about "might be"
- it isn't? ...
and that doesn't qualify as:
"it isn't is what it is, when what it is, is what it isnt it doesn't, no!"
That's it!

PAPERGUN

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AUTHOR'S NOTES

CONTEXT FOR P A P E R G U N

Context for P A P E R G U N

A dramaturgical companion to the song cycle for performance preparation and audience understanding. It is offered here as context, not instruction.

The arc of all three acts is what's important to travel.

tosh42.com

Paper Gun is built around a single sustained dramatic question: what does it cost a person to stay conscious inside a relationship that is slowly consuming them? The answer unfolds across three acts — The Trap, The Struggle, The Emergence — each named after a paper object. Gun. Crown. Heart. The progression is not accidental. A gun is a threat, an instrument of control disguised as power. A crown is the same thing worn more elegantly. A heart is what remains when both have been set down.

The vehicle for the journey is a one-man performance: one piano, one performer, two voices. Those two voices are not characters in the conventional theatrical sense. They are two sides of the same person — and the deepest reading of the piece is that they are two forces that live inside every person who has ever been caught in a difficult bond with someone they cannot simply leave.

The spoken voice and the sung voice are not equal in the way two actors in a play are equal. They are in a power struggle. The spoken voice has been winning for most of the story. By the end, the sung voice has claimed itself back.

The two voices have been given the designations E and N throughout this working document. These are not names. They are orientations.

E — The Self-Destructive as the protagonist / The Sung Voice

E is the voice that feels, reaches, questions, and ultimately does the work of the piece. E is the one capable of vulnerability, of theological wrestling, of grief. E sings because singing is the voice of the interior — it costs something to sustain a note, it requires breath and exposure in a way that speech does not. When E sings, the audience is inside the protagonist's experience, not observing it from outside.

E's great weakness is the self-destructive characteristic flaw: he extends understanding so far that he absorbs the other person's reality and loses his own. He questions himself when he should not. He forgives prematurely. He reaches for connection even when the hand reaching back is not open. His arc across the piece is from this kind of self-dissolving generosity toward a harder, clearer form of love — one that includes a boundary.

E is printed throughout this document in deep blue.

N — The Punitive as the Shadow / The Spoken Voice

N is the spoken, accented voice. N does not sing because N does not have access to that register of exposure. N performs. N deflects. N observes himself in the third person, de-

scribes his own behavior with a kind of self-congratulatory detachment, and when cornered, reaches for wit rather than truth.

The crucial thing to understand about N is that N is not a villain. N is a wound given a defense mechanism. The piece never invites contempt for N. It invites recognition. The audience who laughs at N's lines is laughing at something they know. N's function in the piece is not to be defeated. It is to be understood, and finally, in Act Three, to be released.

N's most extraordinary moment comes at the very end of the show — the final passage before curtain. The shadow, who has evaded depth throughout, is given the most spiritually searching words in the piece. This is the inversion that resolves the drama: N, in the act of being let go, speaks truth.

N is punitive only while the shadow has somewhere to point. Through Acts One and Two, N carries much of the other person's voice — her dialogue in Paper Crown, her account of the tavern, her observation of him holding court. When she leaves at the end of Act Two, N cannot be her anymore, and the voice turns inward. In Act Three the accusing voice becomes the supporting one: when things don't seem white or black; so what do we do, we stick at it for what we knew; yet you are imbued with beauty still. Nothing about N has changed. Only what N is pointed at.

The clearest measure of that inversion is musical. You Make Me Rock N Roll belongs to E in Act One, with N interrupting from the edges. In Act Three it is N who sings its refrain. The voice that once broke into the protagonist's song of awakening has, by the end, taken it up on his behalf.

N is printed throughout this document in deep red.

E + N — Integration / The Merged Voice

The moments where both voices are together are the pivots of the piece. They signal that the protagonist is no longer at war with himself. Integration is not the disappearance of the shadow. It is the shadow and the self moving in the same direction. These moments are used sparingly and deliberately: This Is Mine, By Hertz, Faith, Truthful Love. Each one is earned.

E + N together is printed in deep green.

The piece establishes a shadow figure — the other person in the dynamic — through the Frère Jacques motif and the phrase "I'm alright, Jack (Jacques)." This figure is deliberately left unnamed and ungendered in the introduction, which invites the audience to project their own shadow onto the frame.

The shadow is introduced in the Narrator's opening as your French brother — and the word "brother" is chosen with care. It carries the Frère Jacques resonance (the nursery rhyme about someone who will not wake up), the British idiom "I'm alright, Jack" (meaning: I have mine, and your situation is not my concern), and the fraternal-spiritual meaning of a peer who has become an obstacle. All three readings run simultaneously throughout the piece.

However, the songs themselves establish a charge that exceeds the fraternal. The Visitor opens with “in the summer, my lover comes south to visit” — and this framing recurs as a structural motif throughout. Lemon makes the stakes explicit: “without a kiss, a taste of bliss — you’re my little sis?” The line only works because the relationship is romantic, or was. Sister collapses the line into absurdity. Lover gives it its sting.

The shadow is therefore best understood as: the person you chose, before you understood what the choice was costing you. Whether that person is a lover, a parent, a sibling, a mentor, a friend — the audience will know. The piece trusts them to know.

Paper Gun operates on two registers simultaneously. On the surface it is a piece about a difficult human relationship and the long work of freeing oneself from it. Underneath, it is a piece about the relationship between a person and G-d.

This layer is never announced. It accretes gradually, through the passages between acts, through the explicit eruptions in Trauma Response (“Same for G-d. That’s the waste.”), Broken Man (the direct address that becomes a prayer), and Paper Crown (the chain of faith → security → accountability → vulnerability → authenticity → intimacy). The audience who does not know this layer is present will experience a human drama. The audience who does will experience something more.

The parallels of sacrifice and the emotional work of the piece are not ornamental. They are structural. Each passage encodes the emotional problem of its act in legal-philosophical language:

Act One: humility must precede forgiveness. You cannot receive what you will not ask for.

Act Two: sorry, thank you, and I agree come from the same internal place. Working on any one of them develops all three.

Act Three: the fourth stage of sacrifice — cut, receive, and now carry and give — the last two of the four stages of honest transmission. You must be willing to wound to find the truth; to receive it without your ego; to become it, to live it; and finally to give it over not for glory but for itself.

The piece ends not with resolution in the conventional dramatic sense but with an earned and shared return. Beautiful Sunshine comes back. The protagonist wakes up — but this time the waking is not a dream. Frère Jacques is still sleeping somewhere. The final visual instruction is: stay vigilant.

ACT ONE — The Trap — Paper Gun

Act One establishes the dream before it names the weapon. Pressures opens in the dressing room, with the nerves before a performance. This Is Mine follows, the generosity of the performance itself. Beautiful Sunshine is the high afterward, a state of cultivated contentment — the cufflinks, the stairs, the happiness at having had someone who cares. This is the idealized version of the bond, the version the protagonist has been living in or retreating to. The parenthetical stage direction — the tip-off that the whole thing was a dream — is the first crack.

The Visitor is where the shadow arrives in real time. The lover comes south. The dynamic begins immediately: the accommodation, the getting of drinks, the management of the other person's fragility. You and Your Own names the pattern: we hurt the ones nearest to us because proximity permits it. We pass it off as love's unavoidable cost. The piece refuses that excuse without condemning the people who reach for it. E is already working hard to hold things together while N begins to show his shape in the Watcher's Point of View section — observed in the third person, self-regarding, performing reasonableness while possessing a critical eye.

Who Knows Just Why, the pivot song of Act One, is E at his most philosophical and therefore most paralyzed — the Hamlet passage is not decorative; it is the sound of someone who can see the problem exactly and still cannot act.

Paper Gun names the central image: the weapon that looks lethal and isn't, or is. Fear Hate is the universal statement: the piece's deepest warning delivered as E's most open address to the audience. Don't Say Anything closes the act and establishes the silence and the double life — generous in public, absent in private; or vice versa.

ACT TWO — The Struggle — Paper Crown

Act Two is the emotional center of the piece and its longest sustained stretch of difficulty. E is now fully conscious of the dynamic and fighting it while still inside it. Bully the Bully and Phenomenal Heart establish the fighting-back energy — but the crucial self-awareness of "I know in this song the bully is me" prevents the act from becoming a simple confrontation narrative. E is not exempt.

Forgiving and Lemon are the impossible heart of Act Two. Forgiving circles the ask that cannot be met — not yet, not by will alone. Lemon is the argument itself, compressed into something between a folk song and a slap. The structural return of Forgiving's lyric at the end of Lemon — "I'm raw from something I saw" — is the piece folding back on itself, showing the wound that the argument re-opened.

The Space Between is the prayer of Act Two — E alone with the gap between what is and what could be. Trauma Response is the most naked moment in the piece, the one where the theological and the personal are spoken in the same breath without resolution. Broken Man is the direct address — to N, to G-d, to whoever is listening.

Paper Crown is the turning point. The vulnerability chain — faith, security, accountability, vulnerability, authenticity, intimacy — is the architecture the whole piece has been building toward. The Paper Crown is the false security N has been wearing. Setting it down is not defeat. It is the condition for everything that follows.

The Painting and An Artist close Act Two. The Painting is the moment the painter steps out of the picture — and E is left in the beauty of it, alone. An Artist resolves the act: the higher lines, the singing alone together. It is a man explaining that he can't be anything absolute, because he takes from what's around him and has to leave room — and then asking whether the room he leaves is ever actually his. This is what the work is for.

ACT THREE — The Emergence — Paper Heart

Act Three does not deliver triumph. It delivers something more sustainable: clarity, release, and a realistic warmth.

From a Living Grave and Painful Bother are the farewell. They are not cold. The parting in Painful Bother — with its interleaved lines, its dark shared joke about people being pieces of meat — is the most theatrically alive moment in Act Three. Two people finishing each other's sentences as they say goodbye.

By Hertz and Faith are where the two voices begin to move together. The piece does not pretend this is easy: Faith still carries N's last undercut, and Just a Moment Away holds one more deflection before the turn. But it is in Just a Moment Away that N stands down — granting permission to grieve, in his own words. A Love Left Bleeding is what that permission costs. N offers two explanations and E supplies the harsher one himself; they end on an apology that goes both ways. Nothing is healed. They are simply level, and tired — and that is what makes the next piece possible.

Let Me Cry is the release. The Paper Gun reprise puts the weapon down. Your Paper Heart — The only one who stayed. This is N's only song. Everywhere else he interrupts, undercuts, comments, corrects — he is a voice that lives in the gaps. Here he carries the whole thing, and for the first time he has nothing to punish. It arrives directly after Let Me Cry, and the placement is the point. The man finally gives himself permission to grieve, and nobody human comes. The shadow comes. A shoulder, a hand at the tears, you don't have to tell me why. The kindness is real. But the comfort has a second floor to it. There is no one else as close to me is true, and it is also the entire problem. The brokenness is the condition of the intimacy: if the damage mended, the voice would have no reason to stay. The voice that has tormented him for two acts is the voice that never left. He stayed. Whatever else can be said about him, he stayed — and that is exactly what makes him so hard to put down. The melody that closes the song is the one from An Artist, played without its words — the line that asks whether the higher lines are ever free. What moved into that room is the voice still singing to him. Comfort is not free here. It becomes available the moment the litigation stops. That is the mechanism of the whole third act, folded into a single tag.

Coming Home and This Is Mine are the return — Beautiful Sunshine's warmth again, but earned and shared. This Is Mine, first heard in Act One as the generosity of performance, comes back as the act of reclamation — not victory, but ownership. Opera Star closes the evening on giving rather than grievance. Paper Heart, as encore, is E's gift: the piece's most generous statement. The shadow image returns for a split second before curtain. Stay vigilant. The work is not finished. It is only begun.

Dramatic / Structural Terms

Shadow (Jungian)

The psychological term for the repressed or unconscious aspects of a personality — the parts of the self that have been denied, projected outward, or embodied in a difficult rela-

tionship. In Paper Gun, the shadow is both the internal voice (N) and the external figure (the lover/Jacques) who seems to carry it.

Shadow work

The deliberate psychological practice of confronting and integrating the shadow rather than projecting it. The piece is a vicarious exercise in shadow work.

Self-destructive

Used here not in a pop-psychology sense but in the precise dramatic sense: the person in a difficult dynamic who has over-developed their capacity for feeling into the other person's experience, at the cost of their own boundaries. E's flaw is not weakness but excessive extension.

Punitive

Used here dramatically, not diagnostically, and true of Acts One and Two only. There N exhibits the theatrical markers of punitive defense: third-person self-narration, deflection via wit, the inability to apologize first, the use of charm as currency. N is a wound in a suit. In Act Three, with the other person gone and the accent dropped, the same voice speaks without any of them.

Frère Jacques motif

The French nursery rhyme 'Frère Jacques' (Brother Jack / Are you sleeping) runs as a musical and lyrical thread through the piece. Its meaning: the shadow will not wake up. The bells toll. The sleeper does not stir. By the final act, the motif returns transformed — not as a warning but as a farewell.

Paper objects (Gun / Crown / Heart)

The three objects that title the acts encode the dramatic arc: a paper gun is false power, a threat with no real force that nonetheless wounds. A paper crown is false authority, insecurity dressed as sovereignty. A paper heart is the real thing — fragile, actual, offered.

The painting (Turner / Venetian)

The image of the Venetian oil painting in Act Two's soliloquy: when the protagonist speaks his truth, the other person disappears from the scene — the painter steps out of the painting. What remains is beauty, and solitude, and the choice of what to do with both.

Musical / Performance Terms

Live looping

The performance technique at the center of Paper Gun: the performer records layers of piano in real time, building a full musical texture from a single instrument. Dramatically, looping enacts the piece's central theme — the past playing beneath the present, the same phrase returning in new context.

Song cycle

A sequence of songs designed to be experienced as a unified dramatic arc rather than as separate pieces. Paper Gun is in the tradition of the song cycle — the songs are not set-pieces; they are chapters.

Operetta

A form of musical theater that sits between opera and musical comedy — typically more intimate than opera, more dramatically serious than a revue. The designation here signals that Paper Gun has the emotional scope of opera with the accessibility of popular song.

E (sung voice)

The protagonist's interior voice — the one that costs something to sustain. Singing requires breath, exposure, resonance. It cannot be faked in the same way speech can.

N (spoken/accented voice)

The shadow's exterior voice — performed, controlled, deflecting. Speech permits more management than song. N speaks because N is always, to some degree, performing.

Relational / Psychological Terms

Vilify to satisfy

A phrase used in Trauma Response and Paper Crown: the punitive defense mechanism of making the other person the villain in order to avoid accountability. If you are bad, I cannot be wrong. If I cannot be wrong, I cannot apologize. If I cannot apologize, I remain in control.

Paper crown

The image at the turning point of Act Two: the false security of needing to be in control. The crown is paper because it has no real authority — it is a performance of sovereignty maintained by the refusal to be vulnerable.

The post-performance vulnerability window

Not a term used in the piece itself, but a concept relevant to understanding it: the period after performance when emotional defenses are lowered and judgment may be impaired. The piece's ending — 'stay vigilant' — speaks to this – represented by the immediate reappearance briefly on the screen in the video of the shadow back in the painting.

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To discuss availability, venue fit, or pricing — Paul responds personally

A NOTE ON SAFE PORTRAYAL

Paper Gun passes through despair. Act Three opens at the lowest point a person can reach, and it is fair to ask how that is handled.

Research on media portrayals of suicide distinguishes two effects. Sensationalized or detailed depictions — particularly those naming methods — are associated with increased risk: the Werther effect. Portrayals of people who come through a crisis, and narratives of hope, coping and recovery, are associated with reduced suicidal ideation and with people being more willing to seek help: the Papageno effect, named for the character in The Magic Flute who is talked out of despair by other voices.

This piece is built to the second pattern, deliberately. The protagonist survives, and the act moves from the lowest point to recovery. The despair is never left unanswered — a second voice replies within the same song. Contemplation is depicted as something already passed through, described from beyond it rather than as a present intention; one line refers to a means in passing, at the point of deepest despair, and nothing is described, shown or instructional. No action is ever taken or planned, and nothing presents an ending as relief or escape. A method for the living is offered instead, printed in these pages, with the recommendation that it be walked with a trained therapist. A talkback follows the performance, so nobody leaves at the rawest moment without a room to be in. And no one here is ever singled out, addressed individually, or asked to disclose anything.

This describes how the work is made, not a claim about what it achieves.

If you or someone with you is struggling, in the United States and Canada the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline can be called or texted at any hour.

GRIEVING THE LIVING

A practitioner's protocol for mourning a relationship with someone still alive

BY PAUL TOSH · CREATOR OF THE OPERETTA PAPER GUN · TOSH42.COM

This protocol comes from lived practice: to be undertaken with guidance and alongside professional therapy — and from twenty years of performing for audiences carrying losses that have no closure. It is offered to fellow sufferers and to the clinicians who treat them. Nothing here replaces therapy; much here may make it work better.

THE PREMISE: RESENTMENT IS GRIEF STILL LITIGATING

Resentment and grief are the same loss in two states. Resentment keeps the case open — someone did this, someone owes, the account awaits settlement that never comes. Grief is the write-off of a debt accepted as uncollectible: not forgiven — surrendered. Chronic bitterness toward the living is usually mourning that was never permitted to start, because the person is still alive and hope keeps re-filing the claim. The rage does not fade into indifference; properly grieved, it melts into sadness — and sadness, unlike resentment, completes. Progress test: the grieving has succeeded on the day revenge becomes boring. Not resisted — uninteresting.

THE TWO PAINS

"You hurt either way — why not stay in contact?" The pains are not symmetric. Contact-pain is corrosive: it does not merely hurt you, it replaces you — you see yourself through the other's eyes, and the damage compounds, degrading the very instrument that would recover. Distance-pain is clean: an amputation — love with nowhere to go — and it diminishes, because grief completes. One is a disease, one is a wound. Wounds heal; diseases progress.

THE PROTOCOL

Loss of a living person lacks what mourning requires — an event, a date, a ritual, witnesses. Supply them deliberately: (a) a one-page eulogy for the good that was genuinely real — grief needs an object, and the page holds the quiet material the bitterness would otherwise drown out; read it briefly and regularly, though for those who process through dialogue and performance, conversation and expressive work may carry the active grieving while the page serves as anchor; (b) a sealed file — the complete record of harm, one's own wrongs included, written once at full voltage, your Paper Gun, then closed: visited only in therapy, never re-litigated at night (it doubles as a target list for trauma-focused work such as EMDR); (c) a bounded window — fixed start and end dates; boundedness is what licenses the psyche to stop; (d) a physical closing act — the page printed and put away, a composition, a stone: the body must register that a burial occurred; (e) one witness — grief unwitnessed barely registers as having happened; (f) clergy sanction where faith is live, converting private improvisation into authorized practice and answering the "reconcile at all costs" chorus; and (g) a means of expression —

music, writing, art, prayer — as the enabling condition: the outlet is where the unsayable first reaches the front; those without one cannot begin, so building one is the first task.

WHY EXPRESSION ALONE WAS NEVER ENOUGH

But the expression — talk, art, catharsis, even tears — drains the reservoir but does not cap the spring: the relief is real and temporary, and the resentment refills between discharges. Only completed mourning caps the spring. The outcome measure is not the absence of sadness — the ache remains, visitable, for life — but whether the gaps between discharges stop refilling with prosecution. Crying, within the structure, is not breakdown; it is the loop finally running to completion. What is properly wept for stops charging rent.

None of this requires the other person to change, participate, or ever know. The love is not discarded — it is kept, resized to reality, and rerouted to where it can be received. Clinicians interested in developing this protocol into a formal case study are invited to write.

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WHAT PEOPLE SAY

“Last night made me feel like the pre-WWII era of the arts in society. Loved it.”
LIBBY FOX — CHARLESTON HOME CONCERT

“I especially like the substantive intellectual meaning that you weave into your music.”
RABBI DANIEL LAPIN

“I can’t believe the level of artistry you’re bringing to the people in these residential homes.”
JOE TEPPERMAN — AUTHOR & THEATER WRITER

“Really good solid organic original material — it has to be experienced live.”
MIGUEL CAVAZOS — SESSION DRUMMER, LA

“A deeply personal, high value artistic offering. Light, serious, fun.”
MESOUD BENASULY — SESSION BASS PLAYER, NEW YORK
“My office was right near Carnegie Hall — and you’re more fantastic than Carnegie Hall.”
AUDIENCE MEMBER, Linda, Brightview Virginia

“I think I’ve listened to that song a hundred times — but that might be the first time I’ve actually heard it.”
AUDIENCE MEMBER

BRING PAPER GUN TO YOUR ROOM

If you know a room — a theater, a community center, a senior residence, a church, a hall, a living room with a piano in it — please pass this along.

Paul travels in a self-contained performance camper, which makes him available across the United States and Canada: no hotel riders, no staging requirements, no hidden costs. Just a safe place to park.

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WITH THANKS

G-d, my parents, Libby & Laivy Nussen, Malka and Dave Weintroub,

The Tendlers and Pride of the Farm / Star K.

Special thanks to Mesoud Benasuly, Eli Gestetner and Yisroel Ament.

MESOUD BENASULY

For writing and performing all narrative parts.

ELI GESTETNER

For invaluable counsel and funding.

YISROEL AMENT

For backing track production used in the looping, and for guitar and backing vocals.

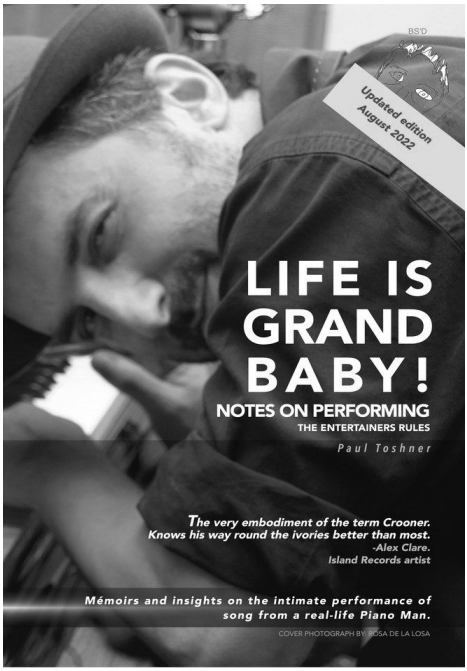
I look forward so much to working with selected tracks into the looper provided by Yisroel: production and mixing, lead guitar (the most amazing guitar work), rhythm guitar, backing vocals, and orchestral arrangements.

SOMETIMES LIVE

Mesoud Benasuly — narration & bass
Yisroel Ament — live musical director & guitarist

Video of this work is at tosh42.com/thanks.html

ALSO BY THE AUTHOR



Life is Grand, Baby!

Notes on Performing — The Entertainer's Rules

Twenty years of what I learned in front of audiences: the instrument, the voice, the songwriting, and the part nobody teaches — how to pay attention to a room. Mémoirs and insights on the intimate performance of song, from a real-life piano man.

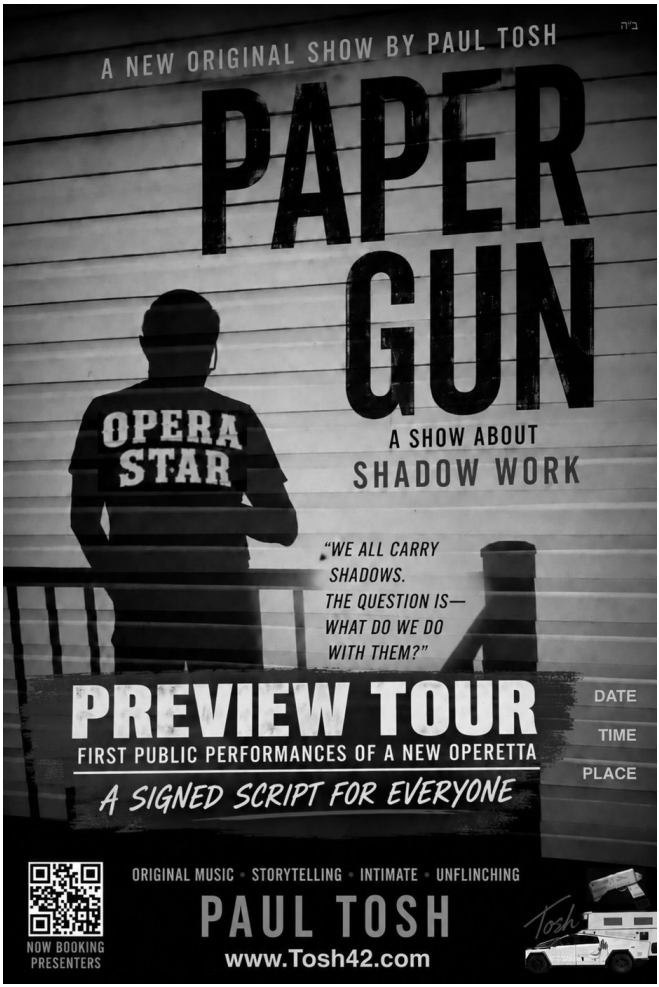
Written long before Paper Gun existed, and in a sense the reason it could.

Available on Amazon — search "Life is Grand Baby Tosh"



We all carry shadows.

The question is — what do we do with them?


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